

CTSE 2026 — 40-Day Roadmap

From: 5 September 2026 · To: 14 October 2026 · Budget: 3–4 focused hours/day ≈ 130 hours total

The one-page strategy

You have three electives but you do **not** have three syllabi. Roughly **60% of the technical content is shared** across Computer Forensic, CS (Degree) and CS (Diploma). Study that shared core once and it pays into all three MCQ papers and all six descriptive papers.

The whole plan follows from four constraints:

Constraint	Consequence for the plan
General paper is first (26 Sep) and its 100 marks count toward all three posts	It gets top priority for the next 21 days. Highest leverage mark-for-mark in the whole exam.
MCQ is 200 marks vs 100 per descriptive paper	MCQ drilling is not optional revision — it is 40% of every elective. Budget real time for it.
Descriptive papers offer choice (8 of 10, 3 of 5, 2 of 4)	You need ~70% syllabus depth, not 100%. Go deep on high-yield topics; deliberately abandon your two weakest per section.
Forensic exam (13–14 Oct) is only 1 day after CS Degree finishes (12 Oct)	Forensic-unique content must be learned during 1–9 Oct , not left to the end. This is the #1 scheduling trap.

Phase map

[Diagram] A flow/gantt diagram is defined here — view it in the HTML dashboard or the source .md. Key labels: gantt · title CTSE 2026 Preparation Roadmap · dateFormat YYYY-MM-DD · axisFormat %d %b · section Phase 1 · General + Core · English mechanics + Digital Logic, COA :p1a, 2026-09-05, 7d · GK core + OS, Networks :p1b, 2026-09-12, 7d · GK finish + DBMS, SWE + mocks :p1c, 2026-09-19, 7d

How the shared core pays into all three electives

[Diagram] A flow/gantt diagram is defined here — view it in the HTML dashboard or the source .md. Key labels: SHARED CORE — study once, scores three times ·] C2[·] C3[·] C4[·] C5[·] C6[·] C7[·] C8[·] C9[·] end subgraph U1[·] D1[·] D2[

Read that diagram once a week. Every hour spent in the blue box is an hour spent on three exams at the same time. Every hour in a coloured box buys one exam only.

Where the hours go

[Diagram] A flow/gantt diagram is defined here — view it in the HTML dashboard or the source .md. Key labels: General English + GK · Shared technical core · CS Degree unique · Computer Forensic unique · CS Diploma unique · Mocks + PYQ practice

Notice how small the CS Diploma slice is. As a B.Tech CSE graduate you already know almost all of that syllabus — **except** MS Office and MS-DOS, which you genuinely may not know and which the paper leans on heavily. That is the whole reason the Diploma slice is not zero.

PHASE 1 — General + Core

5 – 25 September · 21 days · ~70 hours

Daily rhythm: 2 hrs General · 1.5 hrs Shared Core

General comes first because it is the first exam and because its 100 marks are counted into all three of your post evaluations. The shared core runs underneath it every day so that by the time the technical exams arrive you are revising, not learning.

Week 1 · 5–11 Sep — English mechanics + hardware-side core

Slot	Focus
General (2 hrs)	Essay structure and practice · précis method · amplification method · grammar high-yield rules. Write 1 full essay every 2 days, by hand, timed.
Core (1.5 hrs)	CORE_01_DigitalLogic · CORE_02_ComputerOrganization

Week 1 targets: 4 essays written by hand · 2 précis · 3 amplifications · Digital Logic and COA complete with worked numericals.

Week 2 · 12–18 Sep — GK core + systems core

Slot	Focus
General (2 hrs)	Indian Polity (Article 371A is near-certain — know it cold) · Indian History · Nagaland & North-East GK (highest-yield, least-prepared area)
Core (1.5 hrs)	CORE_03_OperatingSystems · CORE_05_ComputerNetworks

Week 2 targets: Polity + Nagaland GK done and self-tested · OS scheduling/paging numericals fluent · subnetting fluent.

Week 3 · 19–25 Sep — GK finish + data core + mocks

Slot	Focus
General (2.5 hrs)	Economy · Geography · General Science · Mental Ability (learn the shortcuts) · Current Affairs revision · 2 full 3-hour mock papers under exam conditions
Core (1 hr)	CORE_06_DBMS · CORE_07_SoftwareEngineering

Week 3 targets: 2 full timed General mocks completed and reviewed · mental ability shortcuts automatic · GK capsule revised twice.

25 Sep — day before

Light revision only. Essay skeletons, amplification structures, Nagaland GK, mental ability shortcuts. Sleep early. **No new material.**

PHASE 2 — Diploma sprint

26 – 30 September · ~4 days

🎯 This phase is almost entirely MS Office and MS-DOS. Everything else in the

Diploma syllabus you already know from your degree. Do not waste this window re-reading networking basics — go straight at the things you don't know.

Day	Plan
26 Sep (after General exam)	Rest the afternoon. Evening: start CSDip_02_MSOoffice_and_DOS — MS Word + Mail Merge.
27 Sep	MS Excel (formulas, absolute vs relative referencing, function syntax, charts) · MS PowerPoint · MS Access · Diploma MCQ drill
28 Sep	MS-DOS internal vs external commands · BAT/EXE/COM · Windows accessories · hardware & motherboard facts · viruses · full Diploma MCQ mock
29 Sep	Morning: light revision of Paper-I topics only. 13:00–16:00 Paper-I . Evening: Paper-II topics (OS, UNIX, DBMS, SAD, C) — these you know, just refresh.
30 Sep	09:00–12:00 Paper-II · 13:00–15:00 MCQ.

PHASE 3 — Degree + Forensic build

1 – 9 October · 9 days · ~35 hours

⚠ **The critical phase.** Forensic sits one day after CS Degree ends, so there is no room to learn it later. Forensic-unique material gets a daily slot here or it does not get learned at all.

Daily rhythm: 2.5 hrs CS Degree unique · 1.5 hrs Forensic unique

Days	CS Degree track	Forensic track
1–3 Oct	CSD_02 System Software & Compilers — assemblers, loaders, linkers, compiler phases, FIRST/FOLLOW, parsing	FOR_01 Forensic science fundamentals — Locard's principle, physical evidence, chain of custody, crime scene, Indian FSL structure
4–6 Oct	CSD_01 Algorithms — complexity, D&C, greedy, DP, NP-completeness · CSD_03 AI — search, A*, logic, resolution	FOR_02 System artifacts — Windows registry, slack space, ADS, event logs, Linux & Mac artifacts
7–9 Oct	CSD_03 Machine Learning — kNN, K-means, ensembles · CSD_04 Mobile & Web/PHP · CS Degree MCQ drills	FOR_03 Cyber crime, first responder, order of volatility, imaging & hashing, email header analysis , browser forensics

Phase 3 exit criteria — be honest with yourself on 9 Oct:

- [] Compiler phases + FIRST/FOLLOW: can do from memory
- [] DP worked examples (knapsack, LCS): can reproduce the tables
- [] A* and K-means: can work a numerical example
- [] Order of volatility: memorised in order
- [] Chain of custody + Locard: can write a 10-mark answer
- [] Email header trace: can walk through one

PHASE 4 — Degree finish

10 – 12 October

Day	Plan
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10 Oct	Morning: revise Paper-I topics — programming, data structures, logic design, COA, compilers, mobile. 13:00–16:00 Paper-I . Evening: rest.
11 Oct	Full free day — use it. Morning: Paper-II revision (OS, SWE, DBMS, networks, web, AI, ML). Afternoon: full CS Degree MCQ mock, timed, 100 questions in 2 hours . Evening: review mistakes only.
12 Oct	09:00–12:00 Paper-II · 13:00–15:00 MCQ . Evening: switch hard to Forensic — Paper-I topics and MCQ blitz.

PHASE 5 — Forensic finish

12 – 14 October

Day	Plan
12 Oct evening	Forensic Paper-I blitz: forensic science fundamentals, physical evidence, crime scene, artifacts, logic/networks/OS/COA (already known from core). Skim FOR_05 MCQs.
13 Oct	09:00–12:00 Paper-I · 13:00–15:00 MCQ . Evening: Forensic Paper-II blitz — cyber crime, browsers & email, digital evidence, mobile forensics, plus SWE/C/DBMS/DS from core.
14 Oct	09:00–12:00 Paper-II . Done. 🏁

The daily rhythm that makes 3–4 hours actually work

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] --> B[·] B --> C[·] C --> D[·] D --> E[·] E --> F[

Five rules that matter more than the schedule

1. **Start every session by recalling yesterday's material from memory, before opening any notes.** Retrieval practice is worth several times more than re-reading. If you change one thing about how you study, change this.
2. **Write answers by hand, timed.** These are handwritten 3-hour papers. Reading an answer and writing an answer are different skills, and only one of them is examined. You must know what a 5-mark answer *feels* like in length before exam day.
3. **Never leave a worked numerical un-worked.** Scheduling, page replacement, subnetting, normalisation, K-maps, DP tables, entropy — these are where 10- and 15-mark answers come from, and you cannot bluff them.
4. **Drill MCQs continuously, not at the end.** 200 marks. Every day should end with at least 20 questions.
5. **If a day goes wrong, do not try to make it up.** Skip ahead to the scheduled topic and carry on. A plan you fall behind on and abandon is worse than a plan you follow at 80%.

Risk register — what could go wrong

Risk	Likelihood	Mitigation

Forensic gets squeezed out because CS Degree feels more familiar	High	The 1.5 hr/day Forensic slot in Phase 3 is non-negotiable. Tick it in the tracker.
GK feels bottomless. you keep reading and never test	High	Hard-stop GK reading on 22 Sep. The last 4 days are testing and revision only.
Essay never practised , only "planned"	High	20 marks. Write one every 2 days by hand from Week 1. No exceptions.
MS Office dismissed as trivial , then the Diploma MCQ punishes you	Medium	It is worth ~30–40 MCQ marks. Treat it as a real subject on 26–28 Sep.
Burnout across a 19-day exam window	Medium	Phase 2 and 5 are deliberately short and sharp. Sleep is part of the plan.
NPSC changes the dates	Medium	Three corrigenda have already been issued. Check the site weekly.